

| By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi |

The defining moment in what proved to be the final leg of the Long March by lawyers and civil society to “restore the judiciary”, involved neither the lawyers nor the activists of various NGOs who had been struggling for 16 months to have General Musharraf’s fiat, sacking some 60 superior court judges, overturned. It occurred on March 15 when former prime minister and current Opposition leader Nawaz Sharif, placed under house arrest in Lahore, ploughed through the police cordon in his car and began the march to Islamabad.

This act of open defiance not only set the tone for the massive demonstration of street power that followed on the streets of Punjab’s capital—tens of thousands of people poured on to the streets in violation of a pre-emptive Government ban on gatherings of four or more people—it redefined Nawaz Sharif himself. Sometimes derided for his controversial stints in power in the 1980s and ’90s, and for choosing to flee Pakistani jails for the comfort of a Saudi Arabian palace under Musharraf’s rule, he had lately been stung by accusations of being “the friendly Opposition” and for playing a meek second fiddle to President Asif Ali Zardari. Not any longer. Sharif has firmly established himself as

